

Step 1: Brainstorming and Idea Prioritization

Individual Research, Self-Collaboration, and Selection of the Problem Statement

Project Title : BookNest - Online Bookstore Management Platform

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1. Overview

This document records the first stage of my BookNest project: how I approached idea generation, conducted preliminary research on my own, and arrived at a clearly defined problem statement. Since this project was carried out individually rather than as part of a team, the brainstorming and prioritization process described below reflects my personal research, self-review, and decision-making, rather than a group discussion.

2. Preparation and Self-Assessment

Before starting development, I set aside time to understand the scope of the assignment given by my mentor and to prepare myself for the ideation process. Since I worked independently, this stage involved reviewing my own skills, the tools I was comfortable with, and the kind of application I could realistically design, build, and deliver within the project timeline.

- **Assignment review:** My mentor assigned the topic of building an online bookstore management system (BookNest). I reviewed this brief carefully to understand the expected scope before starting any design or research work.
- **Self-assessment of goal:** I identified the core problem I would need to focus on for the brainstorming session that followed, based on the assigned topic.
- **Research on existing systems:** I looked at how traditional and existing online bookstores operate, to understand common gaps in inventory handling, order management, and user administration.

3. Defining the Problem Statement

Based on my research and the topic assigned by my mentor, I framed the core problem I wanted BookNest to solve. I used a "How Might We" framing to keep the focus of my planning and design decisions centered on the actual gap rather than jumping straight into features.

PROBLEM STATEMENT

How might I build a centralized digital platform that lets customers browse and purchase books, sellers manage their listings, and administrators oversee users, sellers, and inventory, all from one secure system?

Underlying problem: Existing bookstores often lack an efficient digital platform to manage books, sellers, customers, and orders in one place. Manual processes make inventory management, user administration, and book updates time-consuming and error-prone. BookNest addresses this by providing a centralized online bookstore where customers can browse and purchase books, sellers can manage their listings, and administrators can oversee users, sellers, books, and platform activities through a secure dashboard.

4. Idea Generation and Prioritization

As this was the first project idea I worked on for this assignment, I did not need to choose between multiple competing project concepts. Instead, my brainstorming effort was directed at breaking down the single assigned idea (BookNest) into its core components and prioritizing which parts of the system mattered most for a working first version.

● **Who needs to use the system:** customers, sellers, and administrators, each with different needs and permissions.

● **What is essential first:** secure login and role-based access, book listing and browsing, and order handling.

● **What can follow later:** advanced analytics, notifications, and other enhancements, once the core flow is stable.

5. Principles I Followed During This Stage

Stay on topic	Kept every idea tied back to the assigned problem of bookstore management.
Defer judgment	Noted every possible feature first, without discarding ideas too early.
Go for volume	Listed as many features and user needs as I could before narrowing down.
Be realistic	Prioritized features I could design and build alone within the project timeline.

6. Outcome of This Stage

By the end of this stage, I had a clearly defined, single problem statement to guide the rest of the BookNest project: building a centralized bookstore platform covering customer, seller, and administrator roles. This problem statement was used as the basis for the requirements, design, and development decisions made in the subsequent stages of the project.
